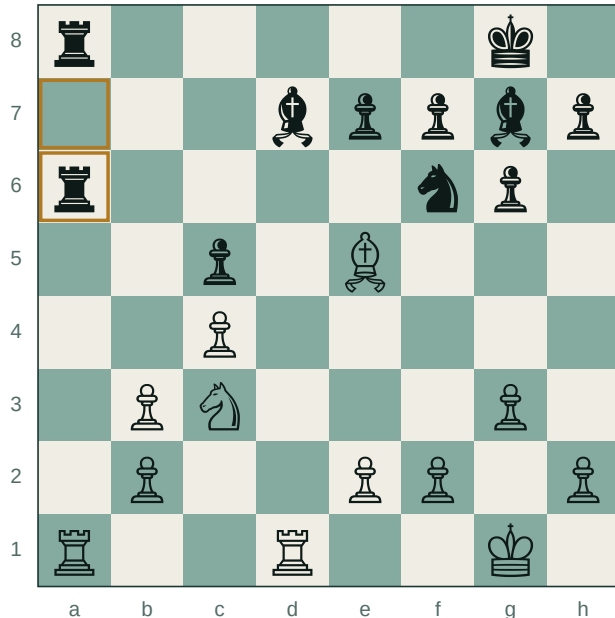


Capture the defender: White, move 19

Capture the defender

White to move



Previous move: 18...Rxa6. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

19. Rxa6 Rxa6 20. Bxf6 Bxf6 21. Rxd7

19.Rxa6 The rook captures the rook on a6. From a6 it attacks rook on a8 and knight on f6. Recorded reply: **19...Rxa6**.

20.Bxf6 The bishop captures the knight on f6. Recorded reply: **20...Bxf6**.

21.Rxd7 The rook captures the bishop on d7.

At the end, nominal material is White 15 / Black 13 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, White's balance changes by +3. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does White's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +3: the balance goes from -1 to +2. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

Do not assume a defender is unique. Another piece may take over its job, or the opponent may decline to recapture.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

Removing a key defender can transform a protected square into a winning entry. The defender's function explains why the first capture matters.

HOW TO LOOK

Identify the protected target, capture its essential defender, and calculate the follow-up after each plausible recapture.

The defending king is on g8. Look for a defender that can be displaced or overloaded.